

who had to smuggle their chemicals from New York, the iodides and bromides labeled “quinine.”

Those not employed by the government had commercial contracts and passes permitting them access in military areas. Brady’s teams were preeminent among them, frequently seen bumping around in horse-drawn portable darkrooms the soldiers dubbed “what-is-it?” wagons. The men worked in pairs, one setting up the tripod and camera, while the other, working in the portable darkroom, mixed the chemicals and spread them over the glass or metal plate, sensitizing it to light. They had but a few short minutes in which to prepare the plate, take the picture, get the exposed plate to the darkroom, and develop it before the fast-drying collodion solution lost its sensitivity. A single exposure might entail a half-hour’s work. The collodion was also limited in its photosensitivity; 20 or 30 seconds might be needed to make a good exposure on overcast days. Photographers either settled for static landscape shots or posed their pictures.

Though the U.S. Army Medical Department compiled seven volumes of photographs of grotesquely disfiguring battlefield injuries, no Civil War images have proved so haunting as the several dozen exposures made of the battlefield dead. Gardner’s depictions of mangled, bloated Confederate bodies at Antietam, when displayed in Brady’s New York gallery, stunned the public. “Let him who wishes to know what war is look at this series of illustrations,” urged Oliver Wendell Holmes. And the *New York Times* noted, “If he has not brought bodies and laid them in our dooryards and along streets, he has done something very like it.”